husband is imprisoned over a corruption and sex scandal. Like her onscreen character, Kajol also marked a return by taking up the role—*The Trial* would be her streaming debut. For Varma, the actress was the obvious choice for the role that Alicia Florrick had popularised in the original show. "For a long time, Kajol has been the nation's sweetheart. Every other film has the hero stealing Kajol away from her fiancé or boyfriend and, here, her husband cheats on her in the very first scene and she has to then rebuild her life," says Varma. "That was a challenge itself, to showcase Kajol in a much more emotionally dramatic role."

The Trial certainly offers the actress plenty to chew on (a far cry from Amit Sharma's segment in *Lust Stories 2*), letting her versatility underscore the dichotomy of the state of modern women in a conservative society. Even the characterisation of Noyonika in the show deviates from how Florrick is written in *The Good Wife*, in that it doesn't only observe the personal and professional hurdles of its lead in isolation. Rather, it places them in the context of Indian culture, where women tend to be victim-shamed even when they are at the receiving end of a life-altering tragedy. The ingenuity of *The Trial*, then, lies in taking a beloved actress and making her simultaneously the face of the empowered woman and the embattled victim. In fact, Kajol's turn in the show is worthy of a comeback role, earnest and complex in equal measure, revelling in effectively earning the viewer's sympathy instead of outrightly demanding it. ■

Poulomi Das



THROWBACK ACT
Rajkummar Rao and (bottom) Dulquer Salmaan in *Guns & Gulaabs*

ENTERTAINMENT

Small-Town Shenanigans

Netflix's ***Guns & Gulaabs*** is a dark comedy steeped in the pop culture of the 1990s

RAJ & DK'S FIRST ORIGINAL SERIES for Netflix, *Guns & Gulaabs* (*G&G*), arrives at a time when the writer-director duo has established themselves as one of the most sought-after voices in long-format storytelling. With this commercial potboiler of a show, they remind us how nobody does quirky, dark comedy better. In *G&G*, Raj & DK along with co-writer Suman Kumar create a delightful world full of the tropes of 1980s-90s cinema. There's a sweet, naive hero, Tipu (Rajkummar Rao), who has his heart set on a woman out of his league and becomes an accidental gangster; there's a dashing police officer, Arjun Verma (Dulquer Salmaan), who comes to town to clean up the mess only to find himself embroiled in one of his own making; there's a menacing villain, Aatmaram (Gulshan Devaiah), with his own legend; and there's a son (Adarsh Gourav) struggling to appease his father and be taken seriously as an heir to the criminal enterprise. Amidst the drug trade and gang rivalries, the fictional town of Gulaabganj comes alive with a love story. There's a sense of familiarity to the fictional landscape of Gulaabganj, but Raj & DK put their own spin to it. Says Raj Nidimoru, "It's our way of looking at that era, but we are not doing a homage." Capturing the 'simplicity' of the time was important. "In the movies then, heroes were always good and villains bad," says Krishna DK. "In *G&G*, the protagonists are unwilling to do a bad thing but are pulled into it."

Steeped in nostalgia it is, but they are also conscious of viewers who may not be clued into 1990s pop-culture references. "We are playing characters now and telling the story to the current generation as well," says Devaiah, who sports a mullet inspired by Sanjay Dutt's in *Khal Nayak*. "I felt like I was in an exaggerated desi spaghetti western, like *Sholay*."

The core of *G&G* though is brotherhood, a vital component of Raj & DK's oeuvre. Through the course of seven episodes, there are three tracks of friendship to follow, each different and constructively adding to the narrative. "The inherent reason it [friendship] comes is that when you are creating a protagonist, you feel there should be somebody bringing him down and pointing his flaws," says DK. "Inherently, that becomes a friend." The brutally honest friend in the Raj & DK universe is not a sidekick but a significant character. Does their own three-decade-old partnership seep into their work? "We are critical of the ideas and the stories we are making," says Raj.

G&G reaffirms that Raj & DK are a school in filmmaking themselves now. DK says, "It feels good what we're doing has been accepted. A decade ago, when we pitched an idea producers wondered how to get it into the mainstream." With the proliferation of OTT platforms, they are now not only mainstream but also prolific. *G&G* is their second series this year after Amazon Prime's *Farzi*. They have developed two others for the platform in *Gulkanda Tales* and *Citadel India*. Another season of *The Family Man* is expected. Says Raj, "There is a self-awareness now. I don't want us to become expected. We were great as underdogs." ■

Suhani Singh

